

The Marwari Mythos

A first novelist sets his potboiler in a business family with a psychedelic cast



THE INHERITORS
by NEEL CHOWDHURY
Random House
Price: Rs 395
Pages: 366

| By Brinda Bose |

The Marwari business family of Kolkata has a near-mythic existence, both in the city and outside it—mainly for its stupendous success in conducting business in a society and a culture (de)famed for its resistance to hard work, its lack of financial acumen and its apparently utter disinterest in notching up economic and industrial achievements to shore up the fortunes of a once-prosperous state like Bengal. Along with its legendary status as a migrant community that occupies a distinctive position in the city, the Marwaris of Kolkata have filled a particularly colourful space in its imagination. They have accrued a kaleidoscopic collection of tales, marking a chequered history that both participates in, and interrogates, the multiple narratives that constitute the lives of Bengalis in Kolkata.

From a privileged ringside seat which gives us rare access to information about many a machination within an extended family, we are invited to witness the tumultuous rise and fall in fortunes of the Lohias, headed by the widower Hari Lohia, an aged patriarch who is desperately, almost pathetically, trying to hold the old order together even as he can hardly stomach the changes being wrought daily by his successors and inheritors

while they wait, vulture-like, for the very same order to pass. A newly-launched manufacturing unit to produce a small car (a la Singur) lies at the crux of the crisis that has now befallen this premier business family in the city. Hirenmoay Chakraborty, ageing Marxist and fiery saviour of the downtrodden masses, has shut this unit down.

The novel's pivot, however, is made of two arresting, astonishing women—Hari's droll, smart other sister Anjali, and his only daughter, the promiscuous, wild and wanton Shivani. When they team up against sibling and aunt Aruna, the stage is set for high drama: for Anjali and Shivani are looking out not merely for themselves but also for their brother and father Hari. The novel's action sequences are located in Kolkata, Mumbai, Singapore, Hong Kong and Rajasthan, and are evocative of the racy lives of its characters.

Kolkata-born-but-not-bred business journalist Neel Chowdhury would appear to be a most promising candidate to spin a fictitious yarn about the Marwaris and their businesses in their adopted state and city, presumably possessing both the right amount of knowledge as well as the necessary distance for fictionalising a piece of socio-cultural, urban, industrial history. That promise is only partially realised, unfortunately. *The Inheritors*, Chowdhury's first novel, accumulates scrupulously a huge number of ingredients that go towards making up a family-cum-business potboiler: a prominent business family with a psychedelic cast of characters, a factory that is under threat of being shut down by an aged but determined Marxist in the city, internal intrigue within the family enhanced by external challenges from a rival Marwari business family, and a plot that races across cities, states and countries with the zip and speed of the very car whose planned inception in a new manufacturing plant is all set to bring about the first business family's ignominious fall from grace. Strangely, almost inexplicably, however, the novel ultimately fails to grip—perhaps simply because it tries too hard.



SAURABH SINGH